needed Bikram Singh to hold the West Ridge, for its capture would open up Walong and cut off the 4 Sikh defended localities. Brigade HQ ordered Bikram to hold West Ridge till 11 a.m. ‘at all cost’.

After their first attack failed to dislodge Delta Company, the Chinese fanned out and assaulted Bikram Singh’s men from three sides. Yet, despite the fact that the men were literally on their last legs, the Kumaonis held out, the young officer roaring like a lion, inspiring his men to fight on. Having held his position beyond the specified time, Bikram Singh asked Brigade HQ for permission to withdraw as he had now run out of ammunition. By then, their position had been completely encircled. One JCO and seventeen other ranks managed to break through the Chinese cordon, but the rest died, all fighting to the end. Bikram Singh was last seen surrounded by the Chinese. Much later, his half-burnt body riddled with bullets was found exactly where he had been last spotted by some of the survivors.

Having overrun the last Kumaoni bastion on the West Ridge, the bulk of the Chinese joined their forward elements that had been harassing and blocking 4 Dogra from reinforcing Trijunction. After a determined effort had allowed the men under Grewal to break through, the rest of the men had fallen back on Mortar Post. Through the night of 15-16 November, the troops had held off the Chinese who were content to keep a loose cordon around the Indian position. After the fall of Trijunction and the West Ridge, the Chinese moved all their troops against the Dogras who were now completely encircled. By then, however, 11 Brigade had issued the order for a withdrawal. Breaking through the Chinese cordon, 4 Dogra headed south towards the Yapak-Lohit junction.

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Patrol Base that had been set up above Lachhman Ridge by 4 Sikh had been the biggest thorn in the Chinese side. Alpha Company’s aggressive patrolling was aimed at threatening the Chinese line of communication between Green Pimple and their rear at Ashi Hill. As a result, there were regular clashes on a daily basis, in some of which the Chinese had been badly mauled. On 15 November, even as the battle for Yellow Pimple was being fought on the slope above, Chinese artillery started intermittently shelling Patrol Base. Not to be cowed down, Major P. M. Samvatsar sent out a patrol to harass the rear of Green Pimple, but the party returned at last light without encountering the Chinese.